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APPS



Uber Eats now lets
merchants message
customers about their
orders



Uber Eats announced on Wednesday that it will now allow restaurants and merchants to chat with customers to help prevent issues with orders. The app is also introducing new AI tools for merchants, and is inviting users to submit photos of their orders if the item doesn't yet have a menu image.

With the new “Live order chat” feature, merchants can message customers in real time to do things like confirm replacements for sold-out items, clarify special requests, and check on dietary or allergy preferences.

Uber states that users can't initiate chats with merchants, as customers can only message merchants if they have contacted them first. Live order chat is available for both delivery and pickup orders, and ends once the food has been handed off to a courier or customer for pickup.

The launch of the new feature comes three months after Uber Eats rival DoorDash [announced the ability for merchants](#) to chat directly with customers to resolve order issues.

As for the new AI tools for merchants, Uber Eats is launching AI-powered summaries of customer reviews to make it easier to understand feedback at scale. Plus, Uber Eats is rolling out AI-generated item descriptions for menus to help users make informed decisions when deciding what to order.

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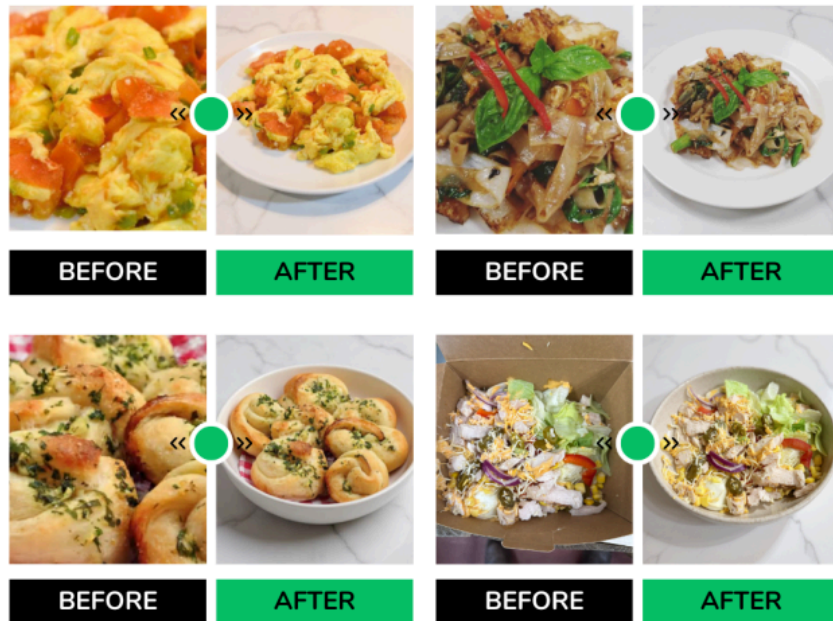
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IMAGE CREDITS:UBER

The app will also use AI to enhance low-quality food images by improving lighting, resolution, framing, and plating. For example, if there's a photo of food in a takeout container, Uber Eats might use AI to generate an image of the same dish on a plate.

In addition, Uber Eats will now encourage users to snap a photo of their delivery. The company says it's doing this because it's aware that customers are more likely to order a dish when they are able to see what it looks like. If a customer's photo is chosen and published, they can get \$3 in Uber Cash if they live in the U.S., Canada, Mexico, or the U.K.

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To submit a photo, users need to tap the “Add Photos” button on the rate order screen after their order is delivered.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

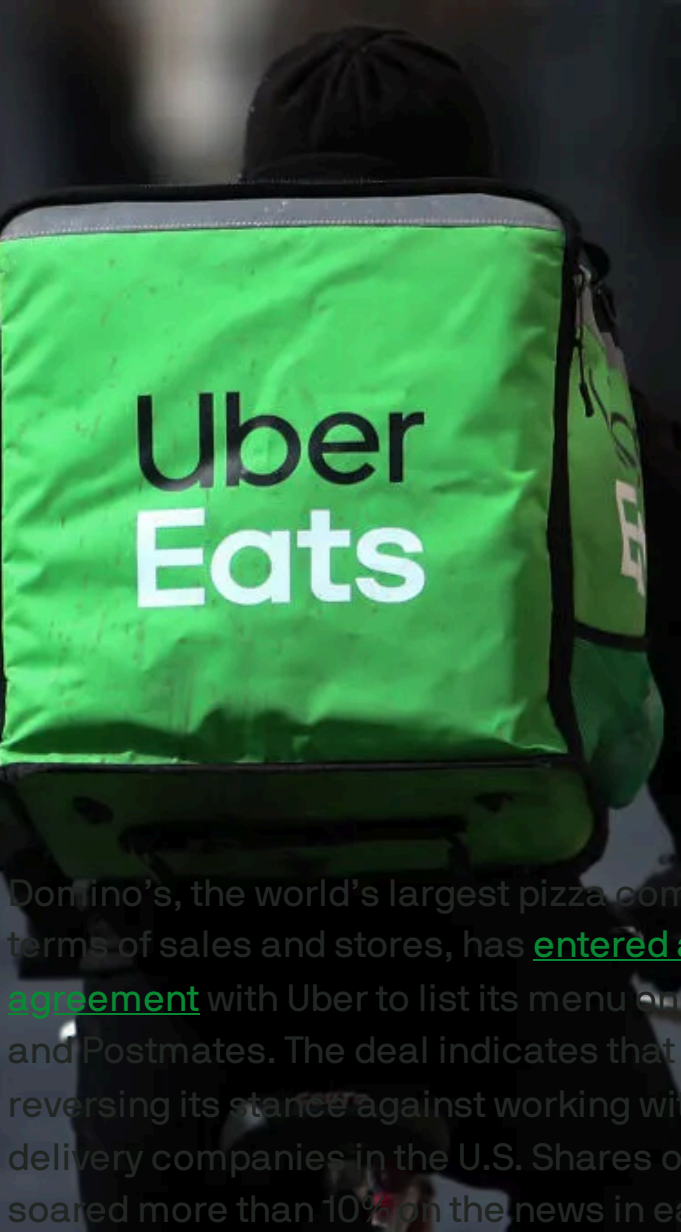
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Domino's strikes deal to list its menu on Uber Eats and Postmates in the US

Aisha Malik — 7:26 AM PDT · July 12, 2023

Domino's, the world's largest pizza company in terms of sales and stores, has [entered an agreement](#) with Uber to list its menu on Uber Eats and Postmates. The deal indicates that Domino's is reversing its stance against working with third-party delivery companies in the U.S. Shares of Domino's soared more than 10% on the news in early trading.

IMAGE CREDITS:

JAKUB PORZYCKI/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

The initial rollout will begin this fall in four pilot markets, with ordering on the Uber Eats and Postmates apps expected to be available across the country by the end of the year. The [Wall Street Journal](#) reports that Domino's is listing its menu on Uber Eats and Postmates in 28 of its markets, including Canada.

Orders placed on the Uber Eats platform will be delivered by uniformed Domino's drivers. After placing an order, customers will be able to track their order using Domino's Tracker or through the Uber Eats app.

The deal comes as Domino's competitors, including Pizza Hut and Papa John's, have already been working with third-party delivery apps in the U.S. since 2019.

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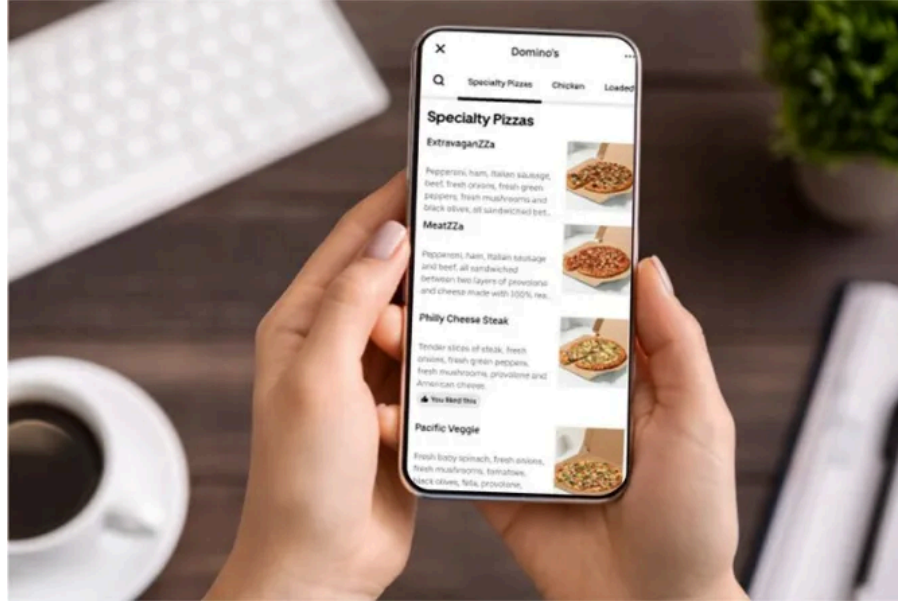


IMAGE CREDITS: DOMINO'S

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“Our research in the U.S. and learnings from 13 of our international markets has shown us that taking orders using the Uber Eats Marketplace provides access for Domino’s and its franchisees to a new segment of customers and what we believe will be a meaningful amount of incremental delivery orders once it’s widely available,” said Domino’s CEO Russell Weiner in a statement.

Weiner told The Wall Street Journal that the chain and its operators aim to generate a billion dollars in new sales by listing its menus on Uber’s apps. He also stated that franchisees will profit from those new sales.

“We’re excited to announce this unique partnership with Domino’s globally—both starting as their exclusive third-party marketplace partner in the U.S. and making their menu available to our consumer base around the world—and we look forward to bringing customers the convenience, technology, and experience that are foundational to both of our brands,” said Uber CEO Dara Khosrowshahi in a statement.



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Domino's says Uber Eats will be its exclusive third-party platform in the U.S. until at least 2024, which indicates that Domino's could potentially make its menu available on other food delivery apps, like DoorDash and Grubhub.

[Uber puts family \(even teens\) at the center of its new products and features](#)

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Aisha Malik

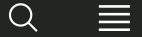
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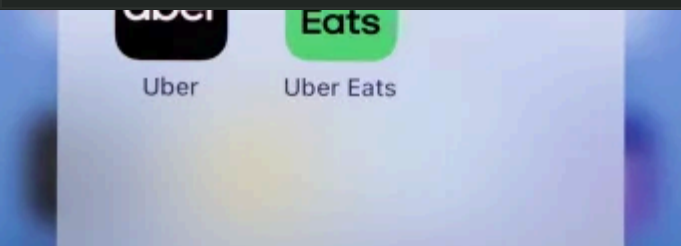


IMAGE CREDITS: STR/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

Aisha Malik — 1:50 PM PDT · August 28, 2023

Uber Eats is developing an AI-powered chatbot that will offer recommendations to users and offer them a quicker way to place orders, according to a new report from [Bloomberg](#). The report says developer Steve Moser discovered details about the chatbot inside of code hidden within the Uber Eats app.

The chatbot will ask users about their budget, food preferences and then help them place an order. It's unknown when Uber plans to launch the chatbot publicly.

Uber did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment.

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Ivan Mehta - 18 minutes ago

AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

The report comes as Uber CEO Dara Khosrowshahi recently told [Bloomberg Television](#) that the company was developing an AI chatbot, but did not share specific details about it. Khosrowshahi did note that Uber already uses AI to match customers to drivers and couriers.

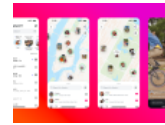
With this upcoming offering, Uber joins other delivery apps that are also looking to incorporate AI into their platforms and services. Earlier today, DoorDash [announced](#) that it's launching AI-powered voice ordering technology that will allow restaurants to increase their sales by answering all of the calls they receive. Plus, the company is [working on an AI-powered chatbot](#) to speed up ordering and help customers find food options.

A few months ago, Instacart [launched an AI search tool](#) powered by OpenAI's ChatGPT. The new "Ask Instacart" search tool is designed to help customers save time and assist them with shopping questions by offering personalized recommendations.

Ever since OpenAI's ChatGPT took over the internet, tech companies have been incorporating AI-powered features into their products to bring more of the technology into consumers' hands. As a result, it makes sense for delivery apps to do the same. Some users may find a chatbot that's able to take their budget and preferences into account a welcome addition to their food delivery app.

Aisha Malik - 12 hours ago

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 17 hours ago

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DoorDash launches AI-powered voice ordering technology for restaurants



DoorDash is launching AI-powered voice ordering technology that will allow restaurants to increase their sales by answering all of the calls they receive, the company announced on Monday. The system will also provide customers with curated recommendations to complement their meal. The company's 2023 Restaurant Online Ordering Trends Report reveals that one in five customers ... Continue reading

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DAVID PAUL MORRIS/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

TRANSPORTATION



Uber Eats to pay millions for listing Chicago restaurants without consent

Rebecca Bellan — 4:28 PM PST · December 5, 2022

Uber has agreed to a \$10 million settlement with the City of Chicago for listing local restaurants in the Uber Eats and Postmates food delivery apps without the restaurants' consent, as well as for charging excess commission fees.

Over \$5 million will go toward paying damages back to Chicago restaurants that were affected, and \$1.5 million will go to Chicago for the costs incurred during the city's two-year investigation into the matter, according to Cohen Milstein Sellers & Toll, a law firm that represented the city.

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Chicago's not the first city to deal with [food delivery apps listing restaurants](#) without their permission, and this isn't Postmates' first offense. Several apps, including Seamless, Grubhub and DoorDash, have been accused of pulling restaurant menus listed online and putting them on their own platforms. When a customer ordered through the apps, couriers would place orders to restaurants on the customer's behalf. Restaurants have said the practice leads to customers ordering menu items that no longer exist or aren't priced correctly, cancelled orders and lack of control over food handling and delivery experience.

"Today's settlement reflects the City's commitment to creating a fair and honest marketplace that protects both consumers and businesses from unlawful conduct," said Mayor Lori Lightfoot in a statement. "Chicago's restaurant owners and workers work diligently to build their reputations and serve our residents and visitors. That's why our hospitality industry is so critical to our economy, and it only works when there is transparency and fair pricing. There is no room for deceptive and unfair practices."

The claims against Uber mirror separate lawsuits from Chicago [against Grubhub and DoorDash](#) last summer that alleged similar deceptive business practices. Both cases are ongoing.

Last September, Chicago reached out to Uber when it discovered the unlawful conduct, according to a statement from the city. The ride-hail company responded by repaying \$3.3 million to Chicago restaurants that had been charged commissions over 15% in violation of the city's emergency fee cap ordinance, removed all non-consensually listed restaurants from the platform and agreed not to list Chicago restaurants without permission in the future.

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Under Monday's settlement, Uber will pay an additional \$2.25 million to restaurants that were allegedly charged commissions higher than the fee cap; \$500,000 to restaurants that Uber listed on its platforms without consent and that don't currently contract with Uber; and \$2.5 million in commission waivers to affected restaurants.



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"We welcome any relief provided to the independent restaurants that struggled throughout the pandemic and continue to shoulder the rising costs of doing business," said Sam Toia, president and CEO of the Illinois Restaurant Association, in a statement.

The city also alleges that Uber participated in deceptive advertising practices like falsely advertising some merchants were "exclusive" to its platform and that certain subscribers would receive free deliveries.

Uber denied any wrongdoing, according to [the settlement](#). Josh Gold, an Uber spokesperson, told TechCrunch:

“We are committed to supporting Uber Eats restaurant partners in Chicago and are pleased to put this matter behind us.”

More than 2,500 Chicago restaurants are estimated to be eligible to benefit from the Uber settlement, according to the [Chicago Tribune](#). Restaurant owners can apply for relief [online](#) by January 29.

Topics: [food delivery apps](#) [Postmates](#) [Transportation](#)

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Rebecca Bellan

Senior Reporter |

Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, where she covers Tesla and Elon Musk’s broader empire,...

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